Birds towers and walls: three successful examples of rehabilitation in province of Varese, Italy

Milo Manica[1,2,3], Daniela Casola[2], Lorenzo Colombo[1,2], Alessandra Stocchetti[2], Costante Cavallaro[1], Stefania Villa[1], Michelangelo Morganti[3,4], Alison Parnell[2]

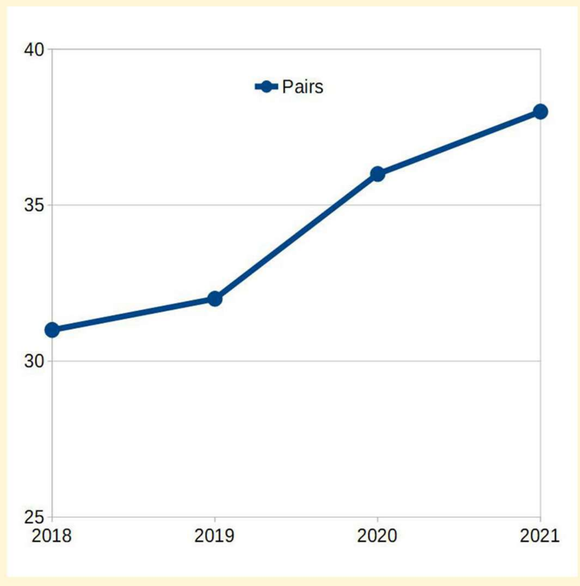
[1] LIPU Birdlife Italia, via Udine 3/A – 43122 Parma, [2] Gruppo Insubrico di Ornitologia, via Manzoni 21 – 21050 Clivio (VA), [3] GreenRes Sezione di Zoologia del MUSE, Corso del Lavoro e della Scienza, 3 – 38122, Trento (TN), [4] CNR-IRSA Via del Mulino 19, 20861 Brugherio (MB)

From 2017 onwards sparrow or swift walls were studied in the province of Varese. This poster summarises how one tower and two walls were renovated to attract breeding swifts. All of these structures were originally built to exploit nesting sparrows as a food source, but have become occupied by Common Swifts *Apus apus*.

The first such site is a tower with 105 nesting cells in Jerago con Orago, a small village with the tower belonging to the municipality. In 2017 the cells were cleaned then in 2018-2019 the wooden frames of the cells were repaired. At this site the swifts were studied by ringing them in a collaborative study together with the universities of Pavia, Milan and Varese. In 2021 there were 38 breeding pairs of Common Swift.



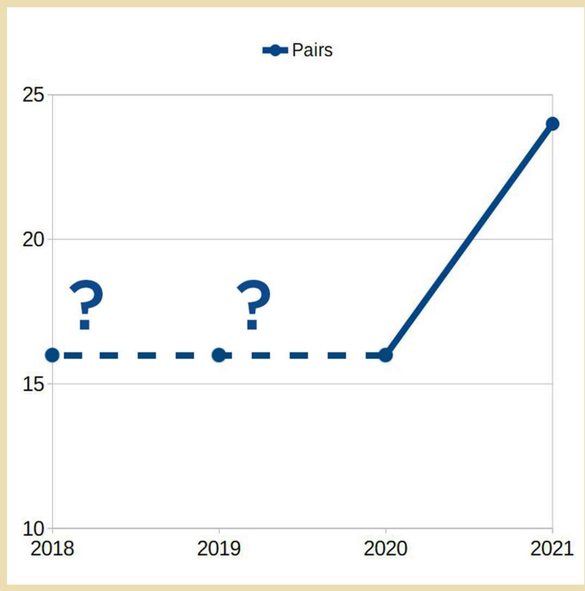




In Azzate, another small village, there was a sparrow wall with 200 cells. With the agreement of the owners the wall, which had been in disrepair since 1979, was renovated. The individual cells were not enclosed which made the cells impossible for the swifts to nest in. Another problem was that the wall was also accessible to cats. In 2020, 16 breeding pairs of Common Swifts were counted, while in 2021, after renovation, there were 24 breeding pairs.







The last case is in Gallarate, a fairly big city, in which there was a renovated farmhouse with three sparrow walls. Again with the owners' permission, the wooden surrounds of 99 of the nesting cells were replaced in one of the sparrow walls during the winter of 2021-22. In 2020 before the renovation, there was only one attempt at nesting by common swift and 2 by a species of Redstart *Phoenicurus* sp. The situation after the renovation will be closely followed during the 2022 breeding season.





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